



2025 COMPUTER BASED SHSAT

PARENT

GUIDE

Your step-by-step companion for understanding the SHSAT, helping your child prepare, and reducing stress along the way.

QUICK FACTS AT A GLANCE



TEST DATE

October 2025
(for Fall 2026 Admission)



TEST LENGTH

3 Hours Total



QUESTIONS

114 Total
(94 scored, 20 unscored)



SCORING

Each section is scored and scaled separately and then added together to produce a score ranging from 200-700



NEW QUESTION TYPES

11 New Question Types
The Digital format is introducing up to 11 new ways for your child to respond.



ELIGIBILITY

NYC 8th and 9th graders can take the SHSAT, though the exam is different for students in each grade



OLD ANSWER TYPES

Multiple-choice, Grid-in



CALCULATOR

Not Allowed



TEST FORMAT

Digital exam on DOE provided computers
(not at home or on tablets)

PARENT MUST KNOW:

This test score is the only criteria for admission to Specialized High Schools. There are no interviews, essays, or portfolios, just the SHSAT score.



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SHSAT

SUBJECT BREAKDOWN

ELA (57 Q's)

- Reading Comprehension
(Non-fiction Texts,
Literary,
Poem)
- Revising/Editing
(Sentences and Paragraphs)

MATH (57 Q's)

- Algebra
- Ratios
- Percentages
- Geometry
- Data Analysis



2025 CUTOFF SCORES BY SCHOOL

These are minimum qualifying scores, not rankings.



556

Stuyvesant



526

HSMSE



518

**Bronx
Science**



High School of American Studies at Lehman College

504

**HS American
Studies**



505

**Brooklyn
Tech**



496

**Brooklyn
Latin**



518

**Quens HS for
Sciences**



527

**Staten
Island Tech**

PARENT TAKEAWAY:

These scores don't reflect school quality. A higher cutoff does not mean a better school. Focus on fit, commute, and your child's learning style.

5 STEP SHSAT ACTION PLAN FOR PARENTS



01



MARK THE TEST DATE

- Confirm with your school counselor
- Register via MySchools.nyc

PARENT MUST KNOW:

Testing dates sometimes change. Double-check closer to fall.

02



TAKE A DIAGNOSTIC

- Do a free diagnostic test with Bell Curves
- Use the score report to find strengths and weaknesses

CONTACT US AT
shsat@bellcurves.com

03



PRACTICE, ANALYZE, IMPROVE

- Build skills by question type
- Focus on areas of weakness
- Learn why wrong answers are wrong

04



SIMULATE FULL-LENGTH TESTS

Attempt	Goal
1st	Learn format and timing
2nd	Reduce nerves
3rd	Focus on mastery
4th	Final dress rehearsal

PARENT MUST KNOW:

Frequent full-length tests help reduce anxiety and sharpen focus.

05



PREPARE FOR TECH GLITCHES

- Review DOE's makeup policy
- Practice on desktops or Chromebooks (not phones or tablets)

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WHAT'S NEW IN THE SHSAT FORMAT

NEW DIGITAL QUESTION TYPES

- **Drag & Drop** Move one or more math or ELA answer choices into boxes on screen.
- **Multi-Select** Select all correct answers (more than one).
- **Dropdowns** Select the correct answer from a dropdown list.
- **Graphing & Point Selection** Plot directly on a digital graph.
- **Equation Response** Type or click in answers (especially for negatives or fractions).

PARENTS MUST KNOW: STUDENTS MUST PAY ATTENTION TO INPUT INSTRUCTIONS. PRACTICE IS ESSENTIAL TO AVOID INTERFACE-RELATED MISTAKES.

PARENTS TAKEAWAY: CONTENT HASN'T CHANGED, BUT FORMATS HAVE. STUDENTS NEED DIGITAL FLUENCY IN THESE NEW QUESTION TYPES.

EXAMPLE:

Multi-Select: Checking multiple correct choices

In which **two** ways does the poet develop the speaker's point of view in the second stanza (lines 8–14)?

Select the **two** correct answers.

- ☐ A. by describing the mountains' awe-inspiring size and strength
- ☐ B. by comparing the various methods humans use to control nature
- ☐ C. by criticizing the careless actions of humans that harm the natural environment
- ☐ D. by demonstrating how the mountains and the people are able to benefit from each other
- ☐ E. by depicting the unfortunate plight of the mountains with vivid details

EXAMPLE:

Dropdowns: selecting from menus

Liam and Kevin each collect stamps. Liam has twice as many stamps as Kevin. Liam gives 8 of his stamps to Kevin. Liam now has 12 more stamps than Kevin.

How many stamps did Liam start with?

Select the correct answer from each drop-down to complete the sentences.

An equation that relates the number of stamps originally in Liam's and Kevin's collections is $L = \text{Choose...} K$.

After Liam gives 8 stamps to Kevin, the equation becomes $L - 8 = \text{Choose...}$.

By solving the equation, it can be determined that Liam started with Choose... stamps.

WHAT'S NEW IN THE SHSAT FORMAT

EXAMPLE:

Equation Response: Typing or clicking through a built-in input interface

What is the value of x in the equation $6x = 9x + 13$?

Enter your answer in the space provided. Enter only your answer.

$x =$

← → ↶ ↷ ✕ 🗑

1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	0
%	-	.	$\frac{\Box}{\Box}$	$\frac{\Box}{\Box}$

PARENT TAKEAWAY: This style of question, where a student produces the answer, existed on the paper version of the test. However, the input method has changed. On most of these questions, inputting the answer is through typing in the answer and is fairly straight forward. However, there are some answers that have an input interface in which students will need to click to input negatives and fractions.

EXAMPLE:

Drag & Drop: Moving answers into boxes on screen

Which quotations from the poem support the theme that nature's unspoiled beauty is splendid, and which quotations support the theme that human creations detract from natural wonder?

Move each answer to the correct box.

"Above the dingy city-roofs / Blue-white like angels with broad wings," (lines 3-4)

"Pillars of the sky at rest / The mountains from the great plateau / Uprise," (lines 5-7)

"Tunnels their granite cliffs, / Splits down their shining sides," (lines 11-12)

"Wilderness still untamed, / To which the future is as was the past," (lines 17-18)

"The south horizon of the sky; / Welcoming with wide floors of blue-green ice" (lines 24-25)

Nature's Unspoiled Beauty is Splendid

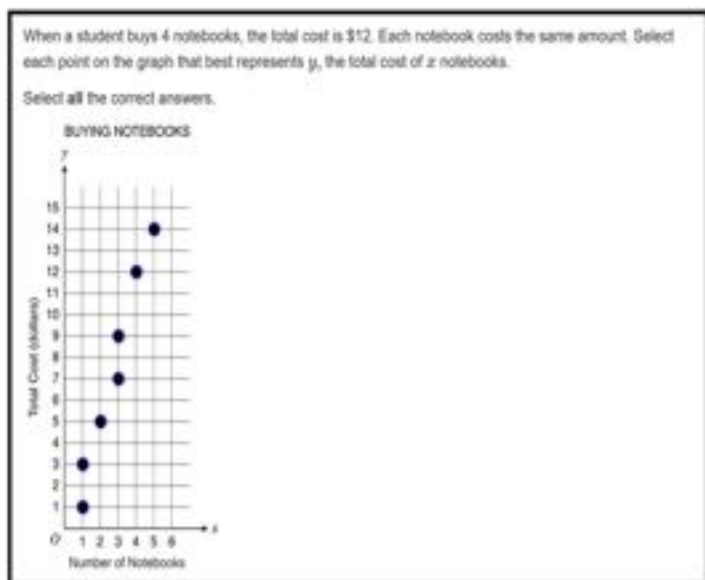
Human Creations Detract from Natural Wonder

PARENT TAKEAWAY: This is the most common new question format and exists for Reading Comprehension, ELA Revision, and Math questions. It is important for students to read these questions carefully as they may be asked to move just one of the items to a box or move all the items into a box.

WHAT'S NEW IN THE SHSAT FORMAT

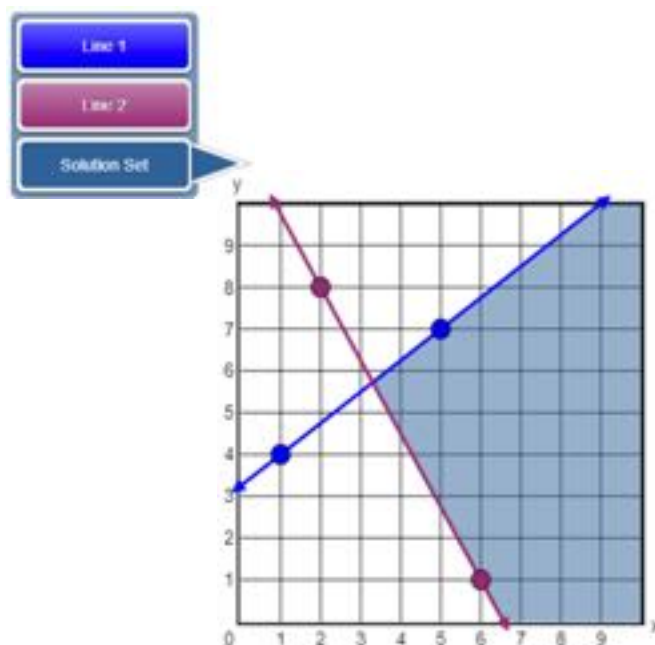
EXAMPLE:

Graphing & Point–Selection:
Plotting directly on digital grids



EXAMPLE:

Solution Set: Calculating line segments and intersecting points.



PARENT TAKEAWAY: Like the drag & drop question type, it is important for students to pay careful attention to the requirements of the question as there may be multiple answers or multiple clicks to input an answer.

PARENT TAKEAWAY: This question type can throw students at first glance because they have to select line segments.

HIDDEN DIGITAL TOOLS STUDENTS CAN USE

- **Zoom Box:** Magnify part of a question or passage
- **Highlighting:** mark portions of text
- **Line Reader Mask:** Focus on one line at a time
- **Answer Eliminator:** Cross out answers
- **Global Notepad:** Carry notes across questions

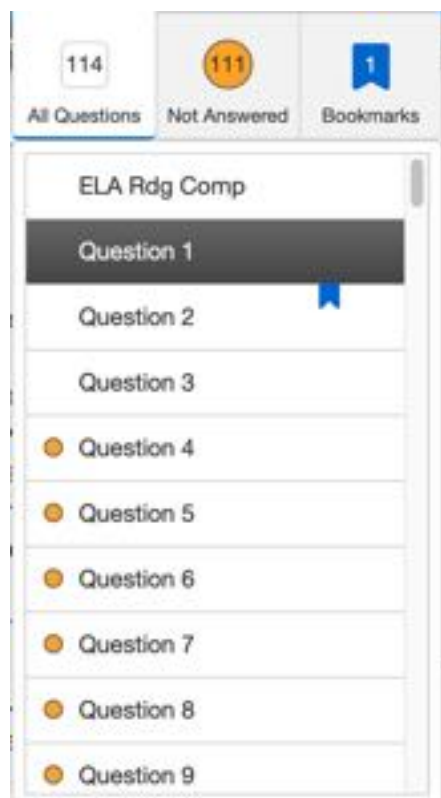


KEY FOR STUDENTS

Practice with scrap paper and a pencil.
Request these at the start of the test.

PARENTS TAKEAWAY

Tools are helpful only if practiced. Use DOE's Student Readiness Tool and Bell Curves practice tests to simulate the digital test environment.



- The navigation and controls for the test can be confusing for students.

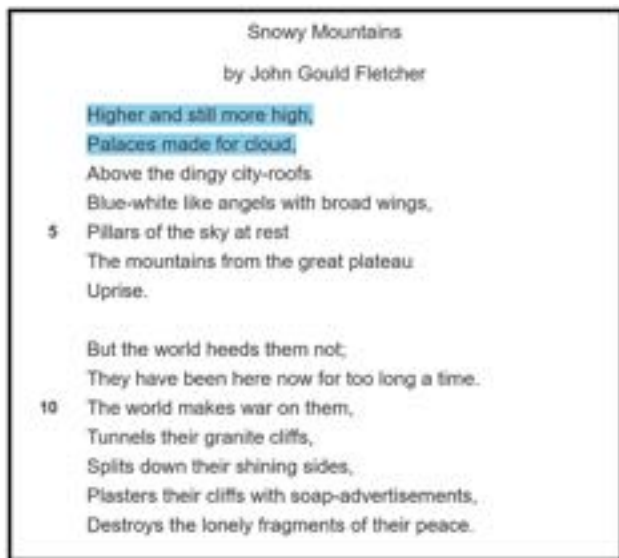


- The navigation and controls for the test may be confusing for students unfamiliar with the tools provided as they are not always intuitive.

HIDDEN DIGITAL TOOLS STUDENTS CAN USE

EXAMPLE:

Highlighting: Highlight specific parts of a passage or question

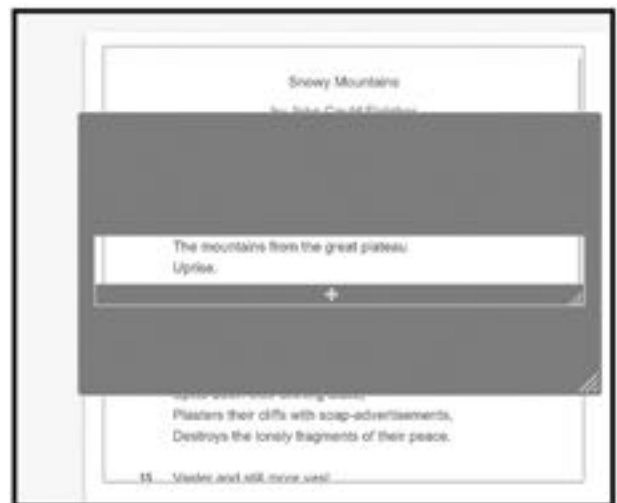


Students can use these buttons to add or remove red and/or green highlights.

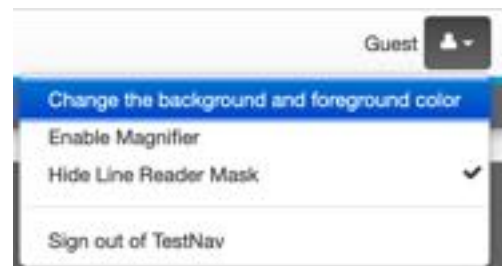


EXAMPLE:

Line-reader mask: Mask parts of a passage, question, or answer choice using masking menu



Enabling the Line Reader requires enabling it in the Profile Menu and adjusting the Line reader box.



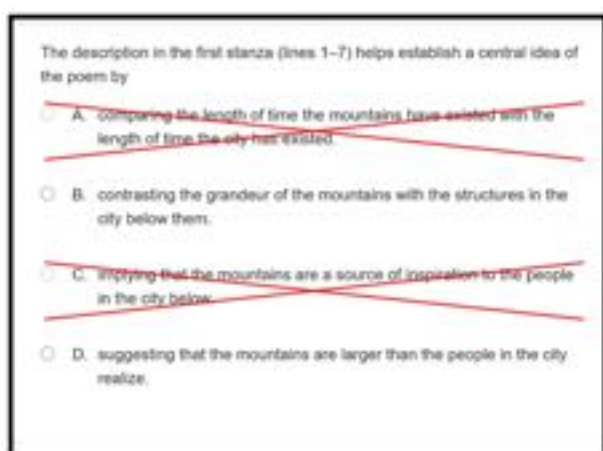
EXAMPLE:

Built-in Zoom: A magnifier box can be used to zoom in on an area of the passages and questions.

HIDDEN DIGITAL TOOLS STUDENTS CAN USE

EXAMPLE:

Answer elimination: Cross out Answers

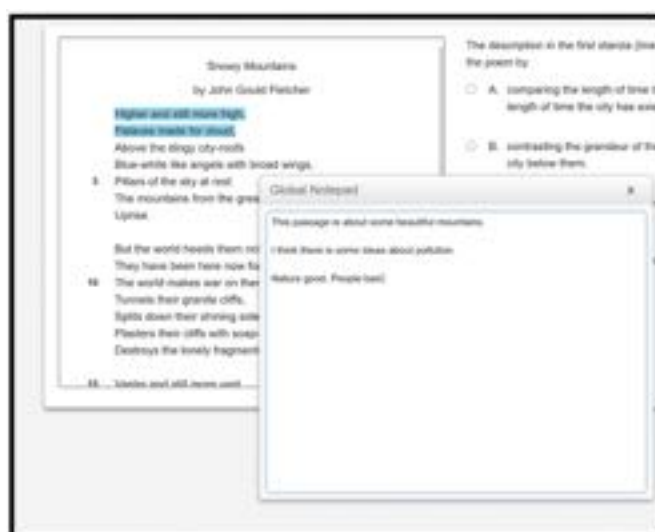


Helps eliminate choices but will allow students to eliminate all choices. Practice using it to avoid confusion.



EXAMPLE:

Global notepad: A place to type in some notes that carry on from question to question

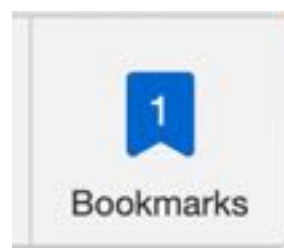
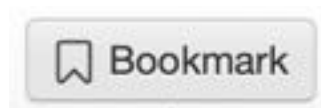


This button opens the notepad.



EXAMPLE:

Bookmark: This allows students to mark a question they want to review later. The button marks the questions and the counter keeps track of the number of questions the student has marked for review. they need to practice using this tool so they can better manage their time.



FINAL THOUGHTS: RESOURCES AND OFFERS

OFFICIAL RESOURCES

- SHSAT Info Hub:
schools.nyc.gov/specialized-high-school-admissions-test
- SHSAT Practice Test:
nycshsat.myassessmentsupport.com/practice-tests
- SHSAT Student Readiness Tool:
srt.testnav.com/ny-shsat/ny-shsat-srt.html



BELL CURVES FREEBIES

- Mini Diagnostic Test (Get a baseline)
- 2025 SHSAT Info Session
New Questions Updated Strategies
July 18th, 2025
- Full-Length Test - Timed and Scored

SHSAT PREP OFFERINGS Coming In July

- Bell Curves AI Test Prep Toolkit:
Mastering the SHSAT
- Virtual SHSAT Course
- SHSAT Workbook (Physical and Online Access)
- Question Bank (2000+ New Questions)
- 5 Full-Length Digital Practice Tests

RESERVE YOUR SPOT:

<http://www.SHSATGuide.com>



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